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What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Paramount launched** a \$77.9 billion hostile takeover offer for Warner Bros. Discovery, taking its case for the acquisition directly to shareholders days after Warner agreed to a deal with Netflix. **A1**
- ◆ **China's trade surplus** in goods this year exceeded \$1 trillion for the first time, a milestone that underscores the country's dominance across a swath of industries. **A1, A2**
- ◆ **Trump said he would** let Nvidia export its H200 chip to approved customers in China and that the U.S. would receive a 25% cut of sales. **A2**
- ◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** declined, with the S&P 500, Dow industrials and Nasdaq shedding 0.3%, 0.4% and 0.1%, respectively. **B12**
- ◆ **Todd Combs, who led** the successful turnaround at Berkshire Hathaway's Geico insurance arm, is going to JP-Morgan Chase to lead a strategic-investment group. **A1**
- ◆ **PepsiCo struck an** agreement with activist investor Elliott, committing to cut costs across the company and lower prices in its slowing food business. **B1**
- ◆ **Ford turned to Renault** to help stimulate its business in Europe, in another sign of the upheaval being caused by Chinese automakers outside the U.S. **B1**
- ◆ **Meta Platforms plans** to hand Facebook and Instagram users in the EU more control over how much data they share to see personalized ads. **B4**
- ◆ **Amazon.com led an** \$81 million funding round for battery startup Blue Current as Amazon expands its fleet of electric delivery vans. **B4**

World-Wide

- ◆ **The Supreme Court** seemed poised to expand the president's power to fire the heads of many regulatory agencies, even as one pivotal justice expressed a desire to insulate the Fed from political pressure. **A1**
- ◆ **Republicans have yet** to coalesce around a health-care strategy just days before an expected vote on extending enhanced Obamacare subsidies. **A4**
- ◆ **Trump backed away** from a vow to release video of a controversial Sept. 2 attack on an alleged drug boat in the Caribbean, including a portion showing the killing of two men who survived the initial strike. **A4**
- ◆ **Pamela Smith, the first** Black woman to permanently serve as the District of Columbia's police chief, said she was stepping down after two years in the role. **A6**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** plans to announce \$12 billion in aid to U.S. farmers as the agriculture sector grapples with the fallout from the president's tariffs. **A3**
- ◆ **Alina Habba, a former** personal lawyer for Trump, resigned as the top federal prosecutor in New Jersey after an appeals court ruled she was unlawfully serving in the role. **A3**
- ◆ **A get-out-the-vote** campaign failed to lift turnout much above historic lows in a Hong Kong election in which the ballot was limited to candidates vetted by Beijing. **A8**
- ◆ **Nigerian security forces** secured the release of about 100 students who were abducted in November by gunmen who stormed their school. **A9**

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European Leaders Press to Be Heard on Ukraine



BUILDING BLOC: From left, Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelenskyy, the U.K.'s Keir Starmer, Germany's Friedrich Merz and France's Emmanuel Macron met Monday at 10 Downing St. in London for talks aimed at influencing the U.S.-led Ukraine peace process. **A8**

Despite U.S. Tariffs, China Enjoys Manufacturing Boom

Chinese companies adapt to Trump's levies and expand sales around globe

President Trump retook the White House almost a year ago promising a manufacturing boom.

By Jason Douglas in Tokyo and Jon Emont in Singapore

He got one—in China. Chinese industrial production broke records this year as

its factories churned out more cars, machinery and chemicals than ever before. Despite the disruptions of tariffs, the country's trade surplus in goods has set a record, as growing shipments to Asia, Europe, Latin America and Africa offset the hit from Trump's levies on direct sales to the U.S. Chinese companies that built their business around low trade barriers to sell into the U.S. have adapted and in some cases are bouncing back. In May, Chinese-owned e-commerce giant Temu's business model of serving up affordable household goods, beauty prod-

ucts and clothes to American consumers looked all but finished. In addition to the tariffs, new regulations ended a loophole that allowed the company to send small packages to the U.S. tariff-free, punishing sales. Today, Temu is once again among the most downloaded apps in the U.S., and business is booming. The Chinese manufacturing juggernaut shows little sign of slowing. China reported a goods trade surplus of more than \$1 trillion for the year through November, while manufacturing output in the

first 10 months of the year was up 7% compared with the same period in 2024. Strip out imports of energy, food and raw materials and China is on track this year to post a surplus in manufactured goods of about \$2 trillion, a huge sum that is on a par with the annual national income of Russia or Italy. That is twice the surplus in manufactured goods that China reported last year. *Please turn to page A2*

◆ **China's trade surplus tops \$1 trillion.....** **A2**
◆ **Trump says he'll let Nvidia export chip to China.....** **A2**

Court Flags It is Open To Greater Powers for President

By JAMES ROMOSER

WASHINGTON—The Supreme Court seemed poised Monday to expand the president's power to fire the heads of many regulatory agencies, even as one pivotal justice expressed a desire to insulate the Federal Reserve from political pressure.

During 2½ hours of oral arguments, the justices probed the limits of President Trump's assertion of virtually unfettered authority to remove agency leaders, despite federal laws that protect them from being fired over policy disagreements.

Justice Brett Kavanaugh pointedly asked Solicitor General D. John Sauer about concerns from economists that a broad victory for Trump in the case would jeopardize the independence of the Fed's board of governors.

"I share those concerns," said Kavanaugh, a Trump appointee.

Still, Kavanaugh and the other five conservative justices were, as expected, mostly receptive to the administration's argument that the president is entitled to more control over dozens of regulatory bodies in the executive branch, such as the Federal Trade Commission and National Labor Relations Board. Leaders of those agencies are appointed by presidents, confirmed by the Senate and serve staggered terms, often with limits on how many officials from the same party can serve at one time. But Justice Neil Gorsuch, another Trump appointee, said he was not convinced the president has the authority to fire agency heads at will. *Please turn to page A6*

INSIDE



JASON GAY

Notre Dame was left out of the playoff, and the Fighting Irish are fighting mad. **A14**

Berkshire Star Joins JPMorgan Ahead of Buffett's Retirement

Berkshire Hathaway is losing one of its top stars just as Warren Buffett makes his exit. Todd Combs, the stock

By Heather Gillers, Krystal Hur and Gareth Vipers

picker who stepped in to lead the turnaround of Berkshire's Geico auto-insurance arm, will decamp for JPMorgan Chase. His departure, announced

Monday, was by far the most unexpected move in a series of executive changes Berkshire unveiled mere weeks before Buffett hands off his CEO role to Greg Abel.

"I was really surprised," said Paul Lountzis, president of Lountzis Asset Management, which owns Berkshire shares. "When you look at the future, it is more murky now than Todd's gone."

Berkshire also announced

that longtime finance chief Marc Hamburg was retiring, and that the company had tapped Snap's Michael O'Sullivan as general counsel.

Berkshire is on the cusp of a new era: Abel, the company's vice chairman and the lead executive of its many noninsurance businesses, will take over. *Please turn to page A10*

◆ **JPM's Dimon forms advisory supergroup.....** **B11**

Recalled Air Bags Aren't Getting Fixed

Automakers say they issue multiple notices, but car owners don't complete repairs

By RYAN FELTON AND PAUL OVERBERG

Brayan Garcia was driving along a highway in his red Toyota Corolla when he slammed into the back of a Ram pickup truck that was stopping at an intersection in West Texas.

Garcia, 22, died at the scene of the early morning crash. His Corolla sus-

tained heavy damage, its hood ripped off. Debris was scattered across several lanes. But despite hitting the truck directly, the Corolla's air bags never went off.

Toyota had recalled Garcia's car in 2020 over a dangerous defect that could stop its air bags from deploying. But Garcia's vehicle hadn't gotten the fix, like millions of others currently on the road.

From 2015 to 2024, about 12 million vehicles were recalled for safety defects that could result in air bags not deploying. These recalls—37 in total—included models made by General Motors and Ford as well as luxury brands such as Mercedes-Benz and Audi.

About 2.6 million, or around 22%, of af-

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The Lavish Weddings Where Crashers Are Welcome—for a Fee

Couples in India are offering total strangers access to their multiday ceremonies

By SHAN LI

NEW DELHI—Jay Singh wanted to find the perfect wedding present for his older sister. He figured jewelry was too common. Ditto crockery or perfume.

Instead, the 28-year-old photographer secretly registered the couple on a website that invites tourists to attend Indian weddings—for a fee. On his sis-

ter's big night, Singh proudly presented her with two American sisters as the star guests.

"I surprised her with the gift of American people and foreigners," he said. "She was happy."

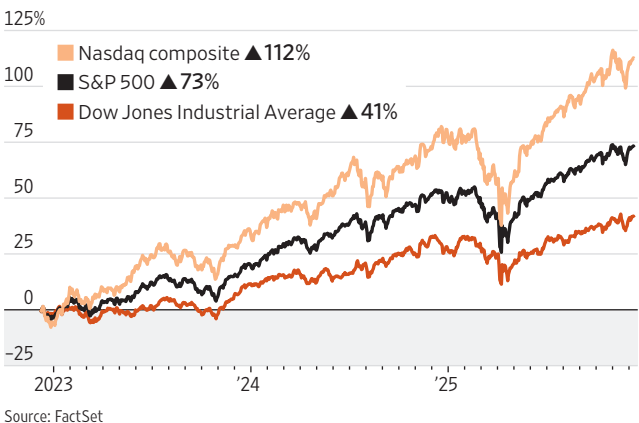
Indian weddings have become a source of global fascination, thanks in part to TV shows like "Indian Matchmaking" and "Made in Heaven."

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401(k) Millionaire Club Grows

A third consecutive year of big gains for U.S. stocks and steady saving by many Americans have boosted retirement account balances, minting more 'moderate millionaires.' **B1**

Index performance during the past three years



Source: FactSet